End-to-End Product Workflow (v2.05) — User Guide

Last updated: July 18, 2026

See your product before you build. Scope deliberately. Scale on a plan that holds up.

From idea to shipped product, end-to-end.

> **WORK IN PROGRESS**
> This workflow is still evolving. We welcome your feedback and appreciate your patience as we continue to iterate and improve.

> **A note on tiers.** Steps 1–8 are the same for every tier. The workflow only branches at **Step 9** (plan the build), so you don't need to nail down your tier before getting started — just confirm it before kicking off `/plan`.

> **A note on file paths.** Claude Code creates and manages the folder structure for you. The only time you'll touch files yourself is in **Step 7**, when you save the prototype's export into your project.

> **A note on screenshots.** Claude Design's UI gets updated regularly, so the screenshots in this guide may look slightly different from what you see. The flow stays the same — look for the same buttons and options even if their styling has changed.

Quick steps

1. **Set up a new application** *(5-10 min)* — in Windows PowerShell or Terminal, install the project template and create your app folder. Repeat for each new project.
2. **Launch Claude Desktop** *(less than 5 min)* and point Claude Code at your app folder. Go to the **Code tab** and change the working folder to the folder you created in Step 1.
3. **Describe your product** *(10-30 min, prep may take longer)* to `/requirements-gathering` in Claude Code. It asks follow-up questions and writes up the requirements for the later steps.
4. **Run `/design-foundation` in Claude Code** *(5-10 min)*. It reads your requirements, decides which screens to prototype, and generates a **visual sitemap** so you can review the selection as a flowchart before you sign off.
5. **Build screens one at a time** *(5-30 min per screen)* in Claude Design. Start a new prototype with the `/Interactive prototype` skill and the **UI mockups** template, drop in the HANDOFF brief with the McDermott design system selected, and steer through screens in flow order.
6. **Share for feedback** *(optional, time varies)* — export the prototype from Claude Design and refine based on what you hear back.
7. **Manually move the project archive** *(5 min)* (Claude Design's full export — not the HTML-only or single-screen options) from Claude Design into your project folder. The next step's skill can't fetch it for you — this is the one manual file move in the workflow.
8. **Run `/design-code-handoff` in Claude Code** *(5-15 min)*. Confirm the archive is in place; it reconciles the plan to match your prototype — **automatically, with no sign-off**.
9. **Run `/plan` in Claude Code** *(15 min)* to start the build pipeline (or hand the project to your developer). Stay available to review what gets built.
10. **Run `/build` in Claude Code** *(45-60 min, depends on product size)* to implement the build plan. Stay available to review what gets built.
11. **Run `/ship` in Claude Code** *(15-30 min)* to finalize and deploy the product.
12. **Test the app locally** *(Build-a-thon temporary, 10-15 min)* — copy the OS-specific prompt into Claude Code to launch the frontend, API, and database locally.

🧰 Step 1 — One-time setup for a new application

Windows PowerShell or Terminal

⏱️ **Time:** 5-10 minutes

> **YOUR PART —** *Install the project template and create your app folder.*

> **PREREQUISITE**
>
> Before starting Step 1, complete the machine configuration guide for your OS — **Windows** or **Mac** (PDF, one-time setup per machine). It installs the tools you'll use below and creates the GitHub access token you'll need.

1. Install the latest solutions template

Run this before every new project so you get the latest template. In Windows PowerShell or Terminal, copy-paste and run one command at a time:

```
npm cache clean --force
npm install -g @alan-eicker/northstar-cli
```

> **Note:** If you get an execution policy error, run this command first:
>
> ```
> Set-ExecutionPolicy -ExecutionPolicy RemoteSigned -Scope CurrentUser
> ```

2. Create your APP folder

Navigate to `C:\Users\[user_name]\` in File Explorer and create a new folder named `claude_apps` if it doesn't exist already. Replace `[user_name]` with your username on the machine — check `C:\Users\` to identify this.

Run these two commands in Windows PowerShell or Terminal. Replace `[user_name]` and `[app_name]` with your actual values:

```
cd C:\Users\[user_name]\claude_apps
nstar create [app_name]
```

You'll get prompted with a few options:

- **GitHub account type?** Enter `1` (Personal).
- **GitHub access token?** Paste the token you created during the machine configuration guide (linked at the top of this step).

> **Note:** The token won't appear in the prompt for security reasons — it will look empty. Just paste and hit Enter.

After this step, a folder named `[app_name]` should exist at `C:\Users\[user_name]\claude_apps\`. Confirm manually using File Explorer.

💻 Step 2 — Open your project in Claude Code

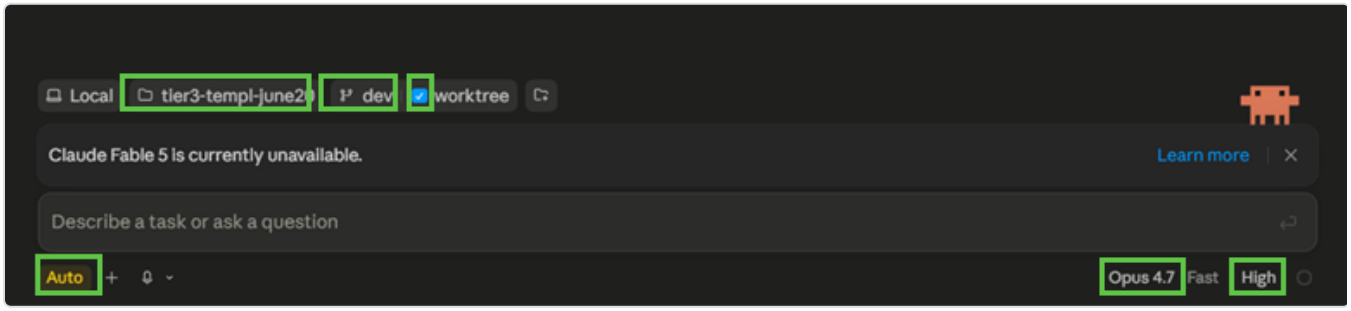
Claude Desktop

⏱️ **Time:** less than 5 minutes

> **YOUR PART —** *Launch Claude Desktop, point Claude Code at your app folder, and confirm your settings.*

Launch **Claude Desktop** and go to the **Code tab**, then make sure these are selected:

1. Working folder: the one you created in **Step 1**
2. Branch: **dev** (with **worktree** checked)
3. Mode: **auto**
4. Model: **Opus 4.7**, **high** effort



Confirm these settings before you run anything: dev branch with worktree, Opus 4.7 at high effort, and auto mode.

📝 Step 3 — Gather your requirements

Claude Code · requirements-gathering

⏱️ **Time:** 10-30 minutes running the skill (meetings to prepare may take longer)

> **YOUR PART —** *Run `/requirements-gathering` to describe your product.*

Within your project in Claude Code, run **`/requirements-gathering`**. Describe your product to Claude — it'll ask follow-up questions and write up your requirements.

> **Tip:** if Claude asks something you can't answer yet, pause and think. Guesses harden into product decisions.

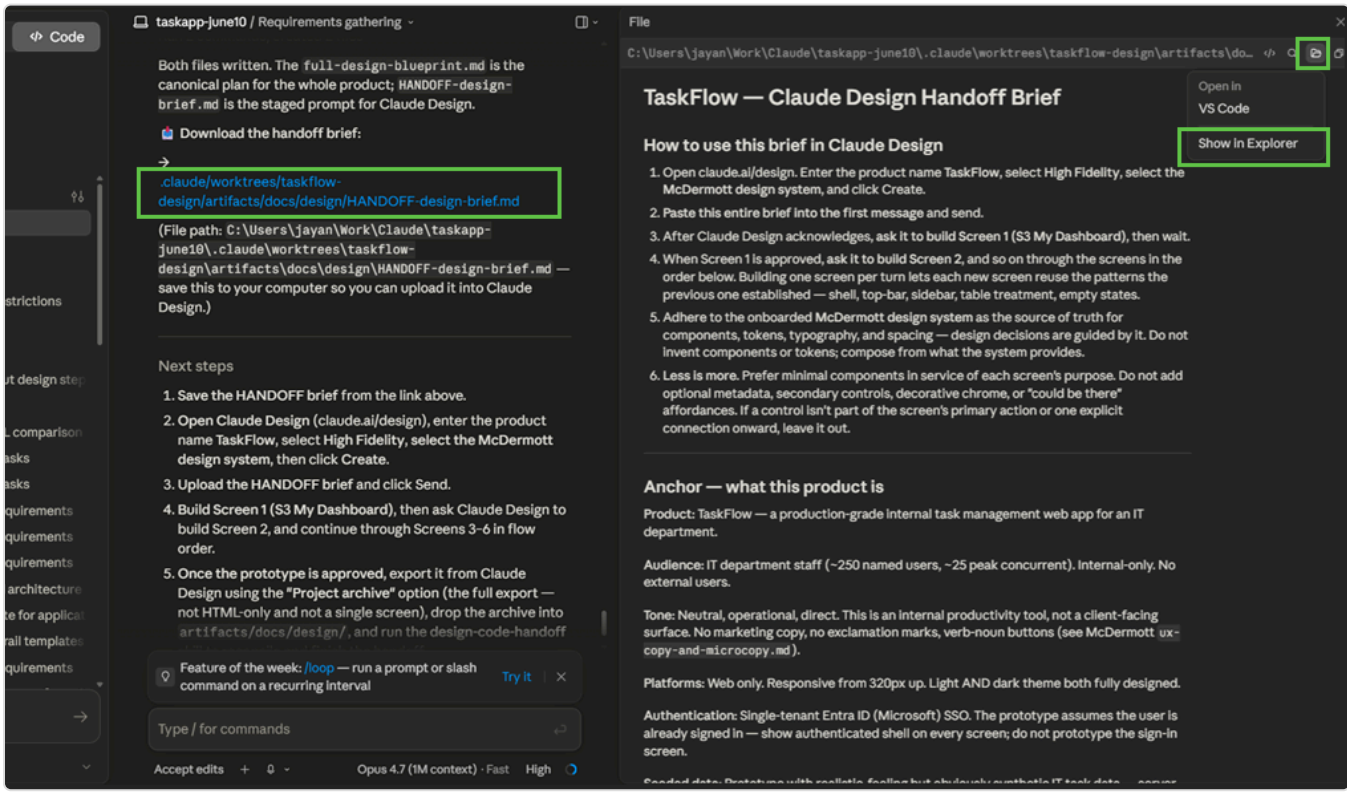
📋 Step 4 — Create a blueprint

Claude Code · design-foundation

⏱️ **Time:** 5-10 minutes

> **YOUR PART —** *Review the sitemap and sign off on the proposed screens.*

1. Run `/design-foundation`. It reads your requirements and writes three files to `artifacts/docs/design/` — the design blueprint, the **HANDOFF brief** (for Claude Design), and a **visual sitemap** of the proposed screens.
2. **Open the sitemap** to review which screens are in the prototype, which are saved for /build, and which Claude suggested adding. Sign off to proceed, or push back if anything feels off — this selection is the most important decision in the workflow.
3. **Save the HANDOFF brief** from the download link — you'll upload it into Claude Design in the next step.



Click the download link for HANDOFF-design-brief.md in Claude Code to save it to your computer.

⚙️ Setup — design system in Claude Design *(one-time, if needed)*

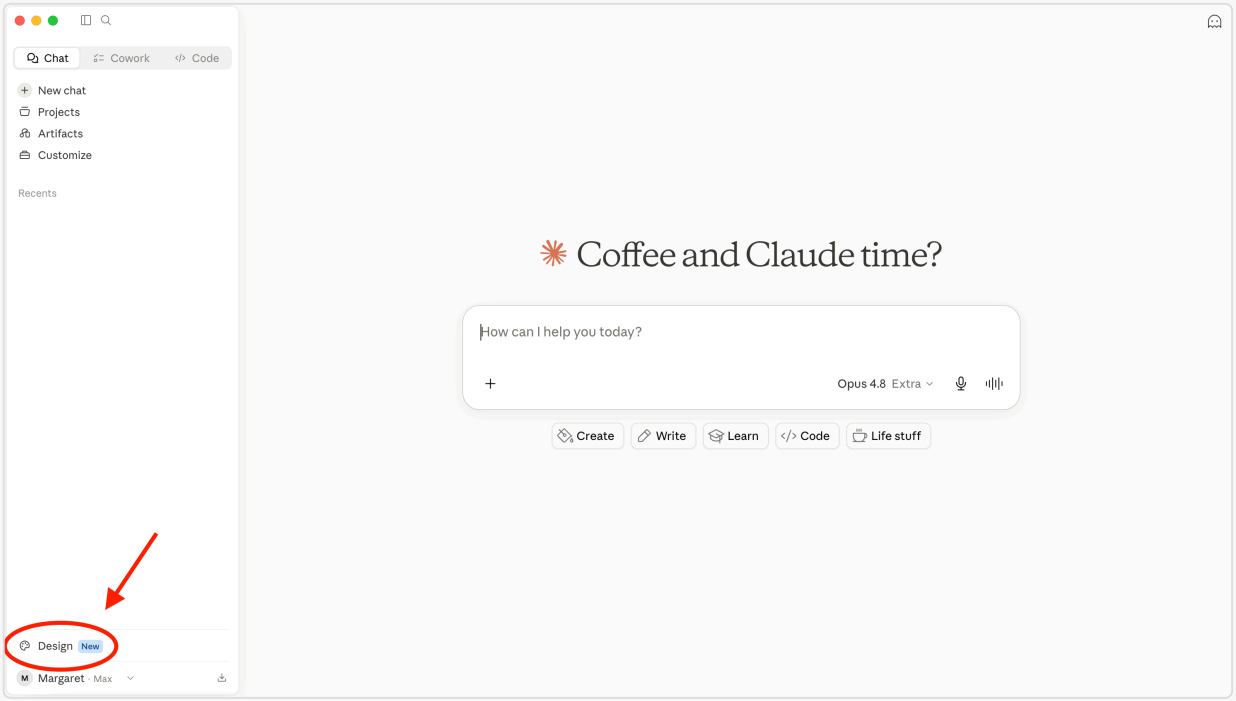
Claude Design

⏱️ **Time:** 5-20 minutes

> **YOUR PART —** *Set up the McDermott design system in Claude Design (if it's not already there).*

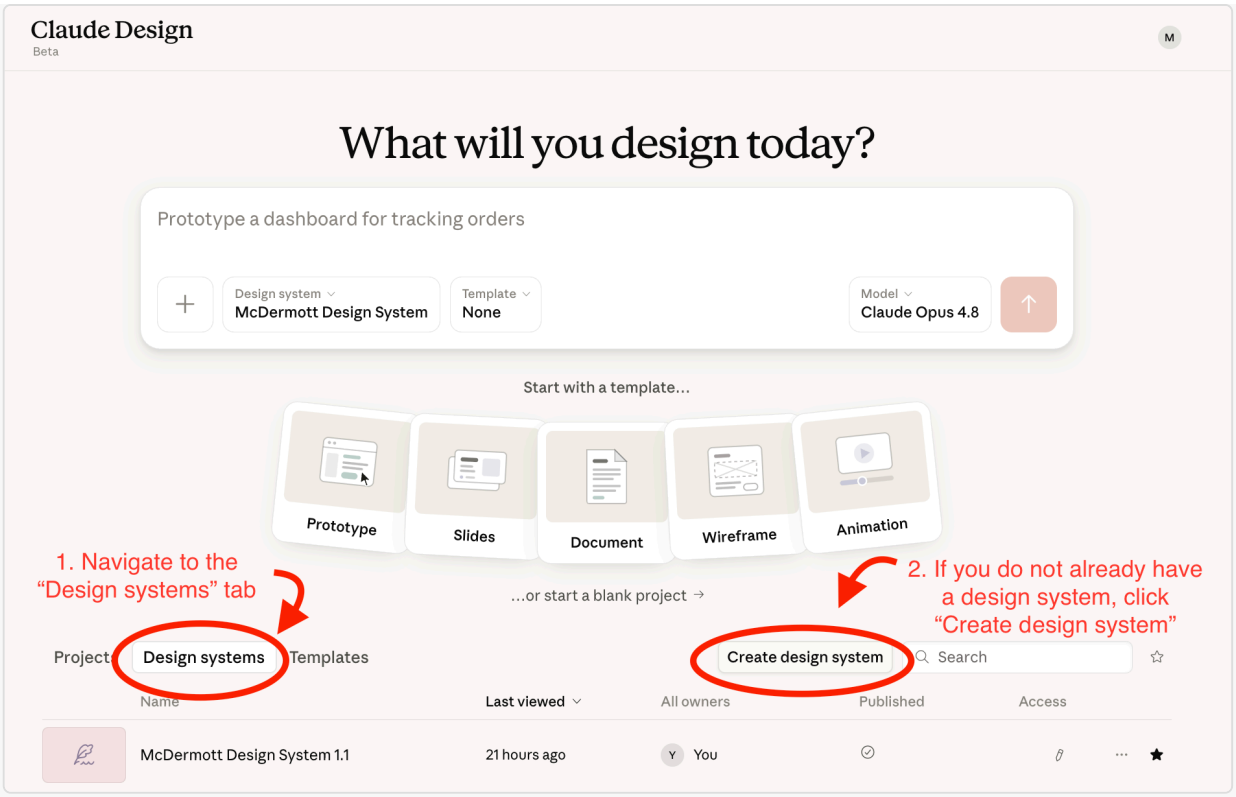
The McDermott design system is the foundation Claude Design uses to build your prototype. The more complete and polished it is, the better the prototype will look — and the closer your final build will be to it.

- Open **Claude Design** in the Desktop App under Chat or Cowork or in your browser at claude.ai/design.



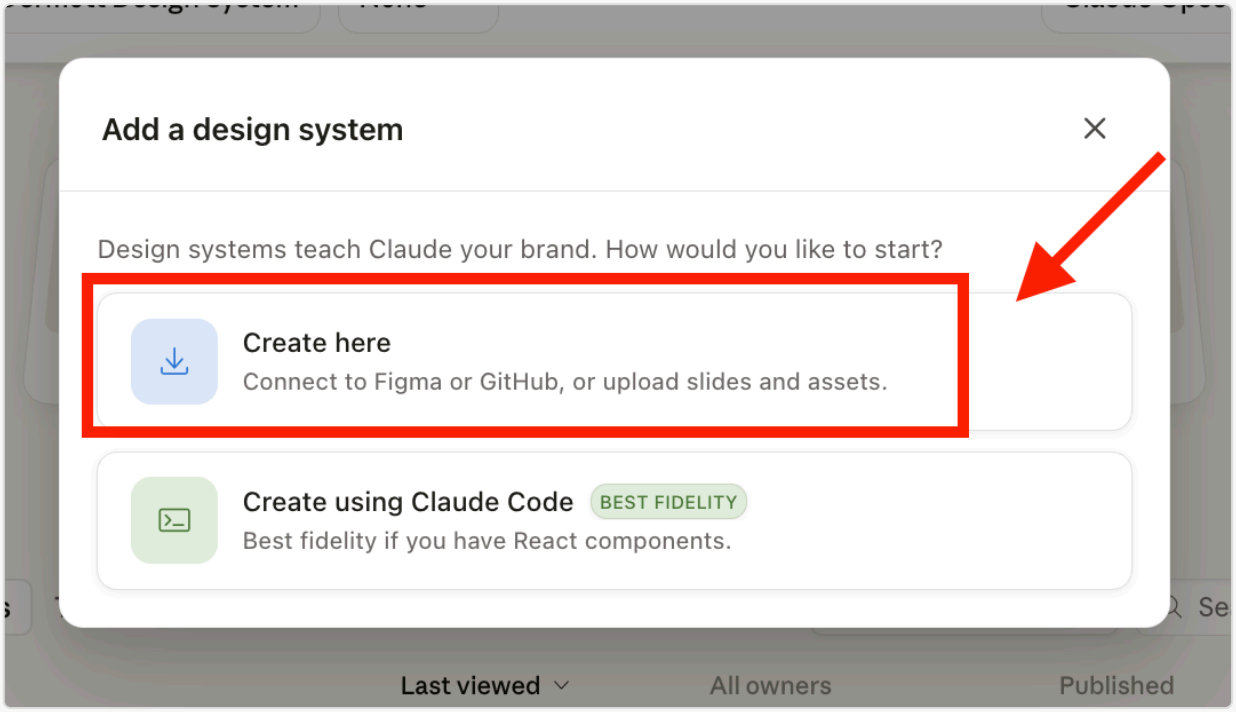
Find Claude Design in the Desktop App under Chat.

- Check your design systems list. If you already have a McDermott Design System, you can skip the set up process and go to **Step 5 — Build the prototype**. If not, click **"Create design system"** to begin set up.



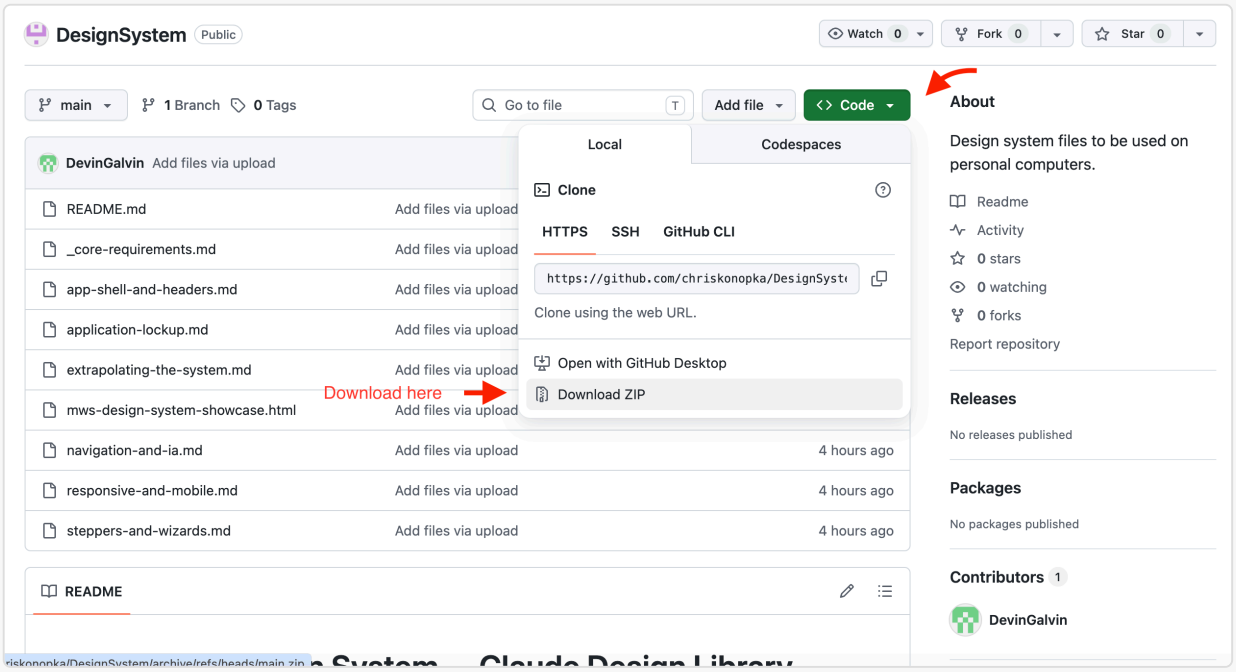
Check your design systems list.

- When prompted, select **"Create here"**.



When prompted, select "Create here".

- Download the latest **McDermott design system file package** from GitHub.



GitHub download: navigate the McDermott design system repo and download the files.

- **Unzip the downloaded folder**, then upload the files into Claude Design through the **"Link code on your personal computer"** option to set up the design system.

> **Tip:** Some users have had trouble uploading the files directly from their Downloads folder. If you run into issues, move the unzipped folder to your desktop (or another location on your machine) first.

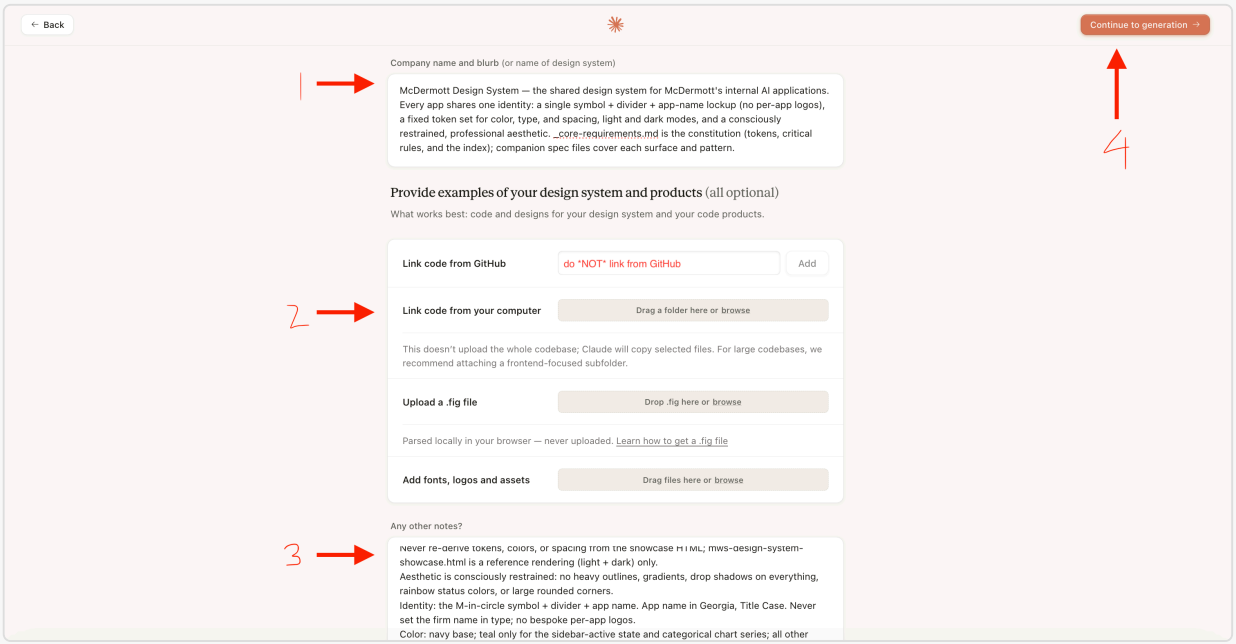
In the "Company name and blurb (or name of design system)" field, paste:

> McDermott Design System — the shared design system for McDermott's internal AI applications. Every app shares one identity: a single symbol + divider + app-name lockup (no per-app logos), a fixed token set for color, type, and spacing, light and dark modes, and a consciously restrained, professional aesthetic. `_core-requirements.md` is the constitution (tokens, critical rules, and the index); companion spec files cover each surface and pattern.

In the "Any other notes?" field, paste:

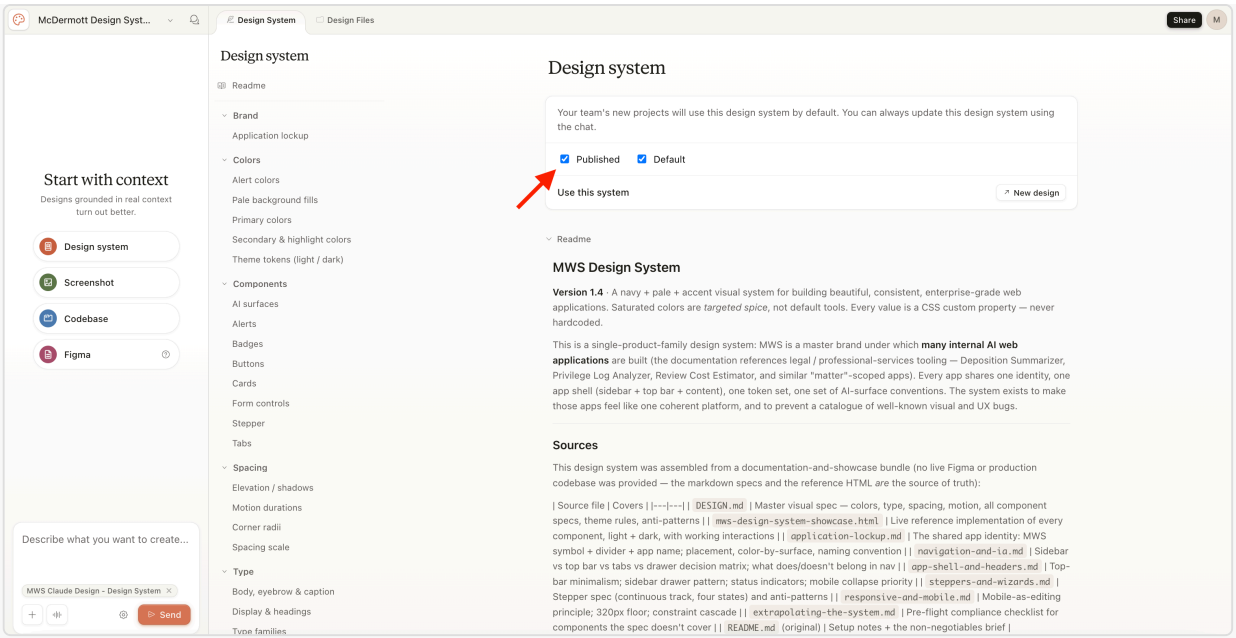
> - The attached folder is the single source of truth. Load `_core-requirements.md` (the constitution) plus the relevant companion specs — small focused files, not one mega-doc.
> - Never re-derive tokens, colors, or spacing from the showcase HTML; `mws-design-system-showcase.html` is a reference rendering (light + dark) only.

- Aesthetic is consciously restrained: no heavy outlines, gradients, drop shadows on everything, rainbow status colors, or large rounded corners.
- Identity: the M-in-circle symbol + divider + app name. App name in Georgia, Title Case. Never set the firm name in type; no bespoke per-app logos.
- Color: navy base; teal only for the sidebar-active state and categorical chart series; all other interactive elements use the accent (blue in light, teal in dark). Both themes required.
- Accessibility target: WCAG 2.1 AA. Icons: Phosphor, outline only.



Set up the McDermott design system in Claude Design by uploading the files.

- Wait for the design system to finish setting up. This may take up to 5 minutes.
- **Publish the design system** to make it available for use in your projects. Without publishing, the system won't show up when you go to build a prototype.



Publish the design system in Claude Design to make it available for use.

- **Verify all components are loaded.** After publishing, paste this prompt into Claude Design to confirm the upload was complete:

  > "List all components, tokens, and patterns from the McDermott design system you can use, and flag anything missing from the upload."

  This catches any gaps before you start building prototypes in Step 5.

> **Tip:** a thorough McDermott design system is the biggest factor in a clean prototype. A thin system (just a logo and a color) produces improvised-looking output. Time invested here pays off at every later step.

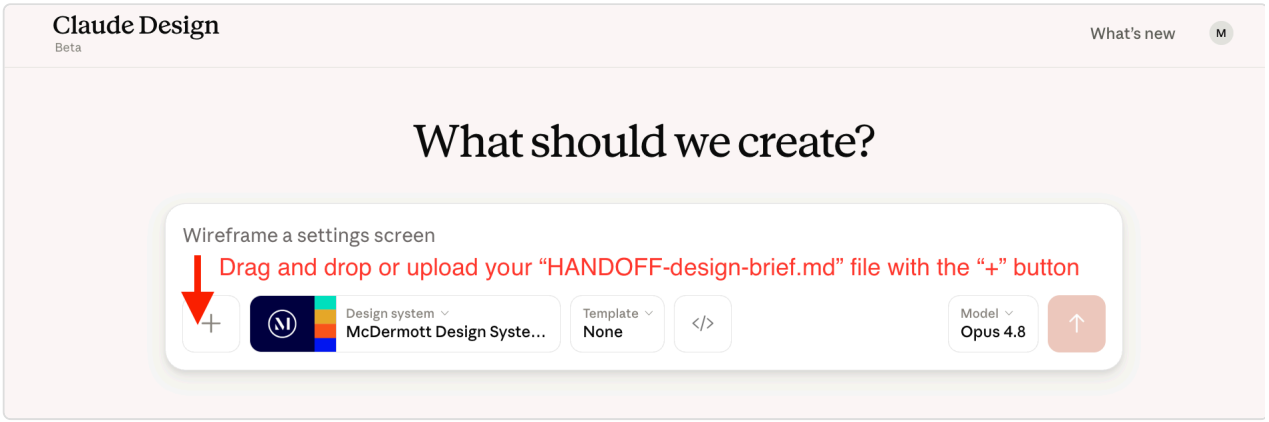
🎨 Step 5 — Build the prototype

Claude Design

⏱️ **Time:** about 5-30 minutes per screen

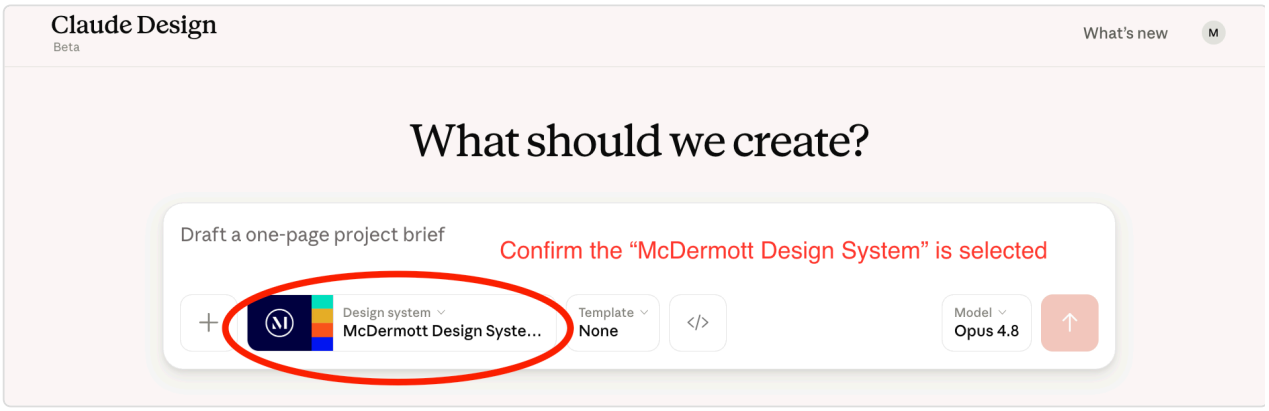
> **YOUR PART —** *Build screens one at a time in Claude Design.*

1. In **Claude Design**, create your design file:
   a. Drag and drop or upload your `HANDOFF-design-brief.md` file (downloaded in Step 4) with the **"+"** button.



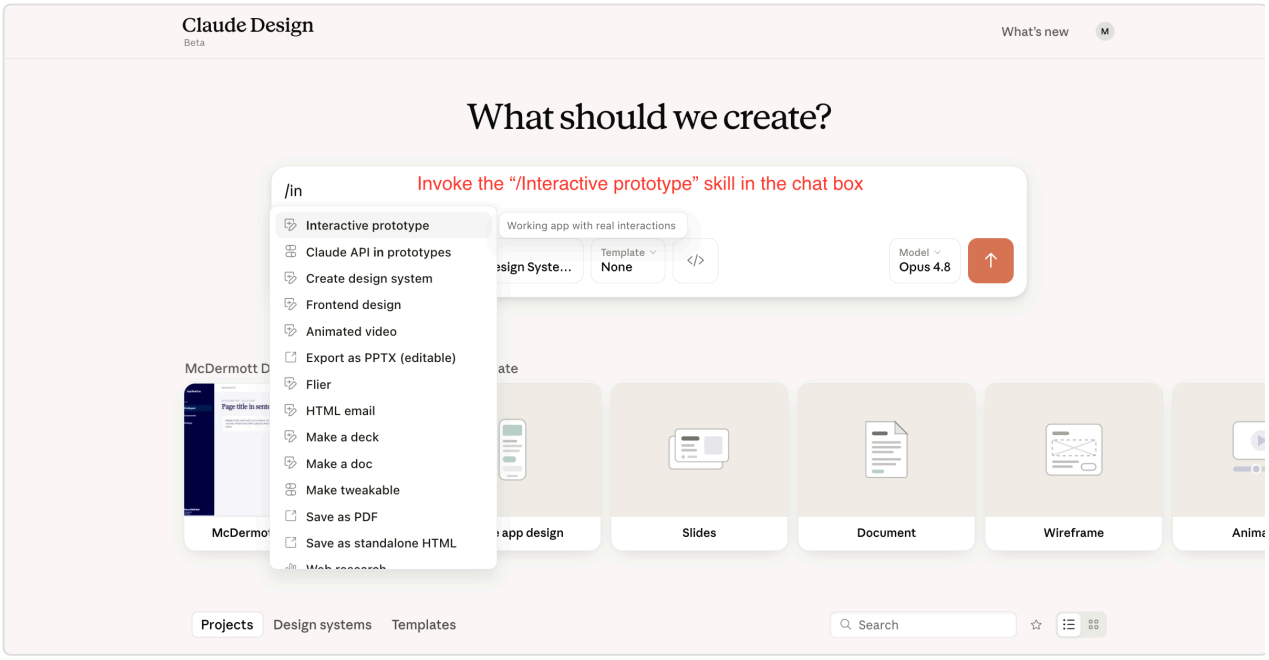
Drag and drop or upload your "HANDOFF-design-brief.md" file with the "+" button.

   b. Confirm the **McDermott Design System** is selected.



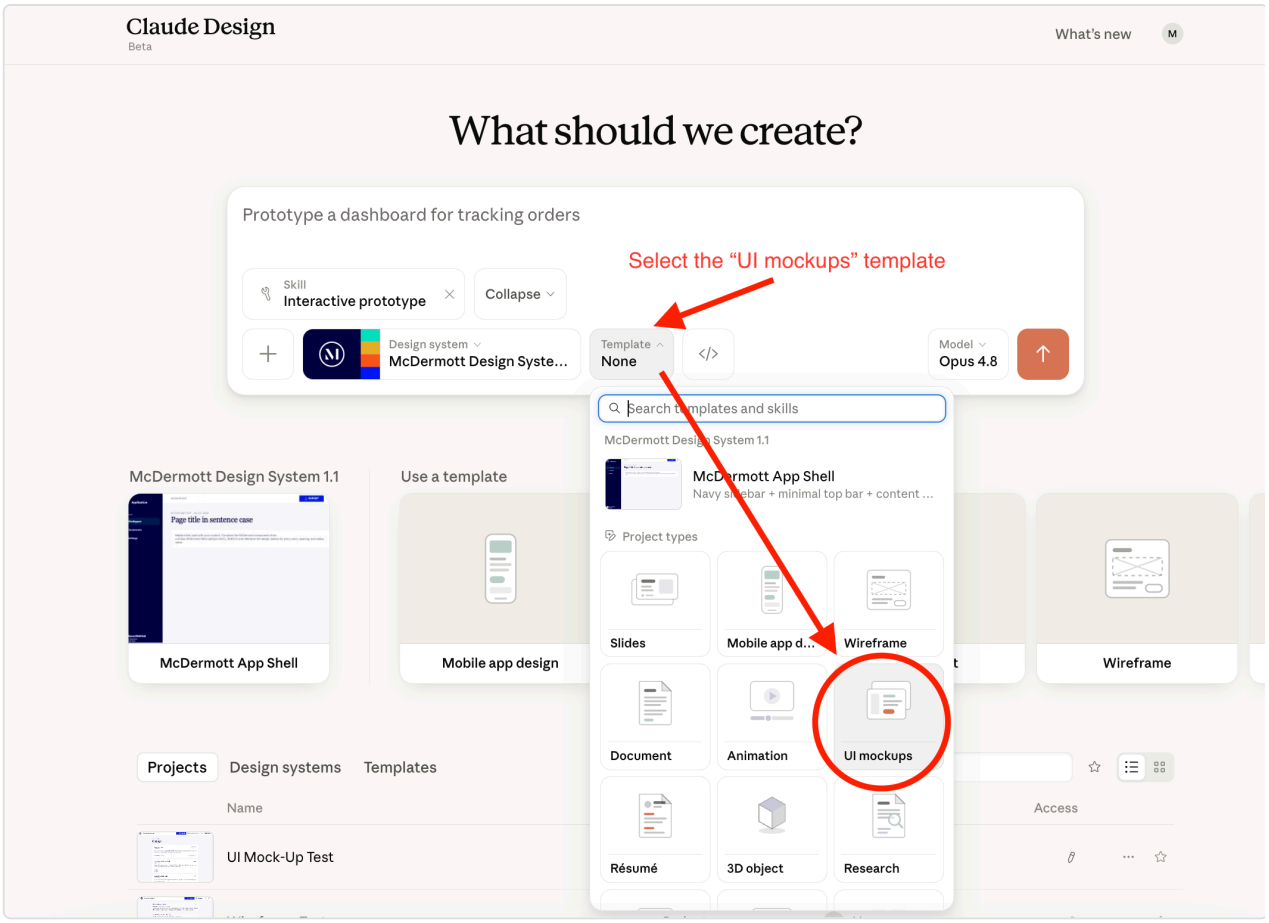
Confirm the "McDermott Design System" is selected.

c. Invoke the **"/Interactive prototype"** skill by typing it into the chat box or adding it under the **"+"** button.



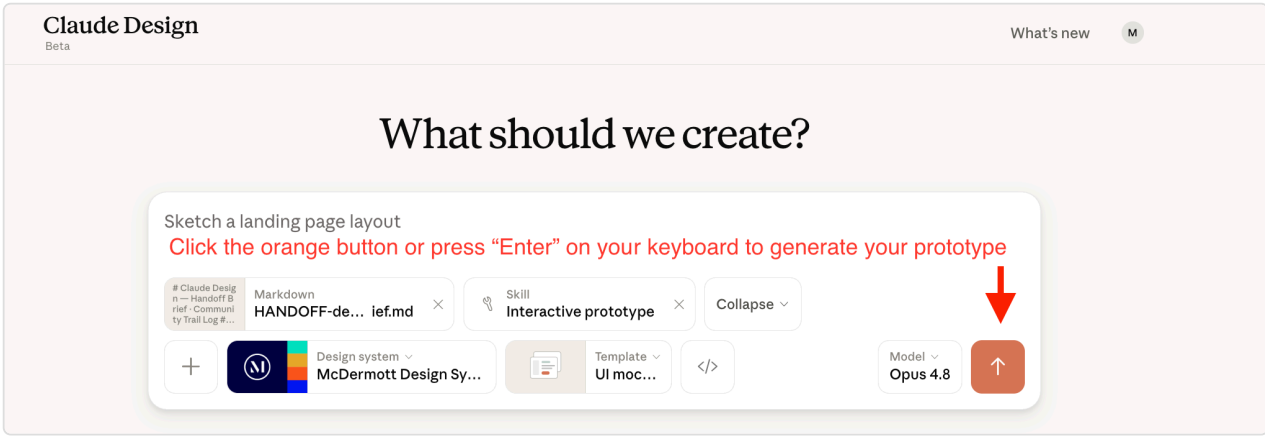
Invoke the "/Interactive prototype" skill in the chat box.

d. Select the **"UI mockups"** template.



Select the "UI mockups" template.

e. Click the orange button or press **"Enter"** on your keyboard to generate your prototype.



Click the orange button or press "Enter" to generate your prototype.

2. **Build screen 1 first.** When you're happy with it, **prompt Claude to build the next one** by saying something like "*now build screen 2*". Continue prompting for each new screen — Claude builds one at a time and won't move forward on its own.

3. Refine any screen by commenting on it, editing text directly, or using the tweaks panel.

> **Tip:** It's fine to build only some of the screens, not all of them. If you stop early — because you ran out of time, decided a screen isn't worth prototyping, or just want to ship what you have — design-code-handoff in Step 8 catches the unbuilt screens automatically. By default it keeps each one as a **"save for /build"** screen (built later from the blueprint), so nothing is lost — it only drops a screen if you explicitly asked to delete it while prototyping. You don't decide screen by screen anymore; it's handled silently and listed in the summary.

💬 Step 6 — (Optional) Share for review

Claude Design

⏱️ **Time:** varies by product

> **YOUR PART —** *Export the prototype and collect feedback.*

Export the prototype as a shareable URL, HTML, PDF, or PPTX. Collect feedback. Refine in Claude Design and re-export until you're happy.

📦 Step 7 — Export the .zip and add it to your project

Claude Design + your computer

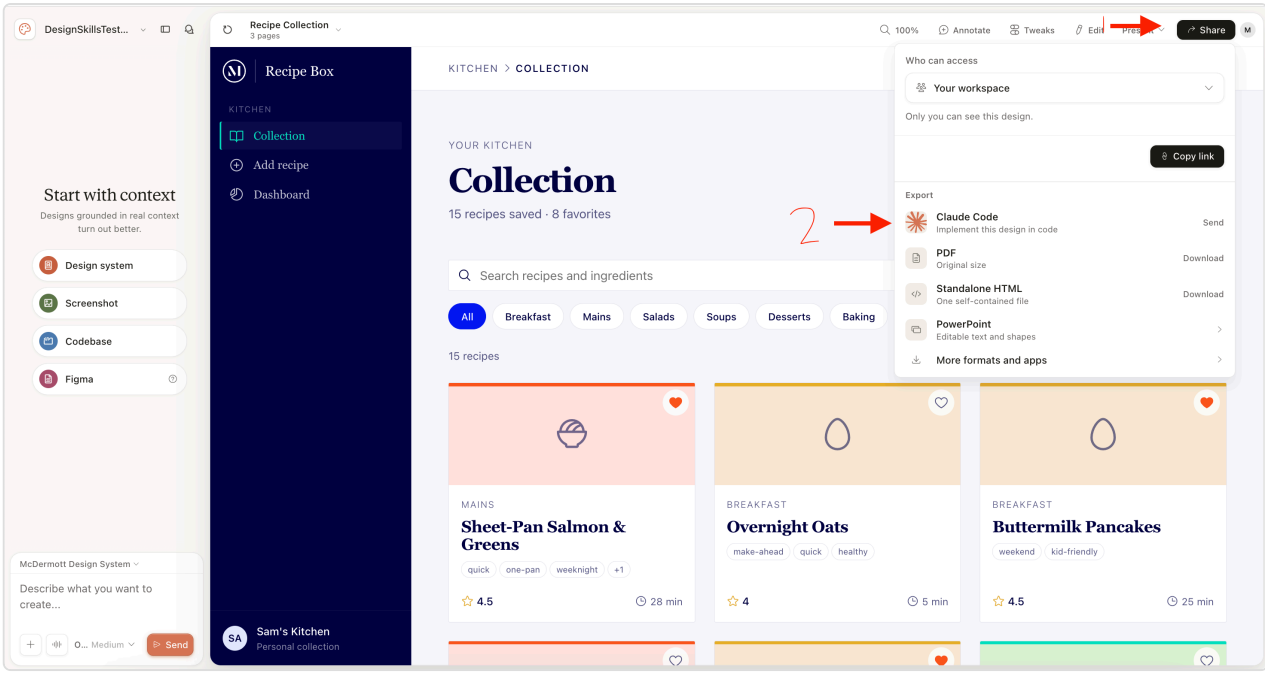
⏱️ **Time:** 5 minutes

> **YOUR PART —** *Move the prototype .zip into your project.*

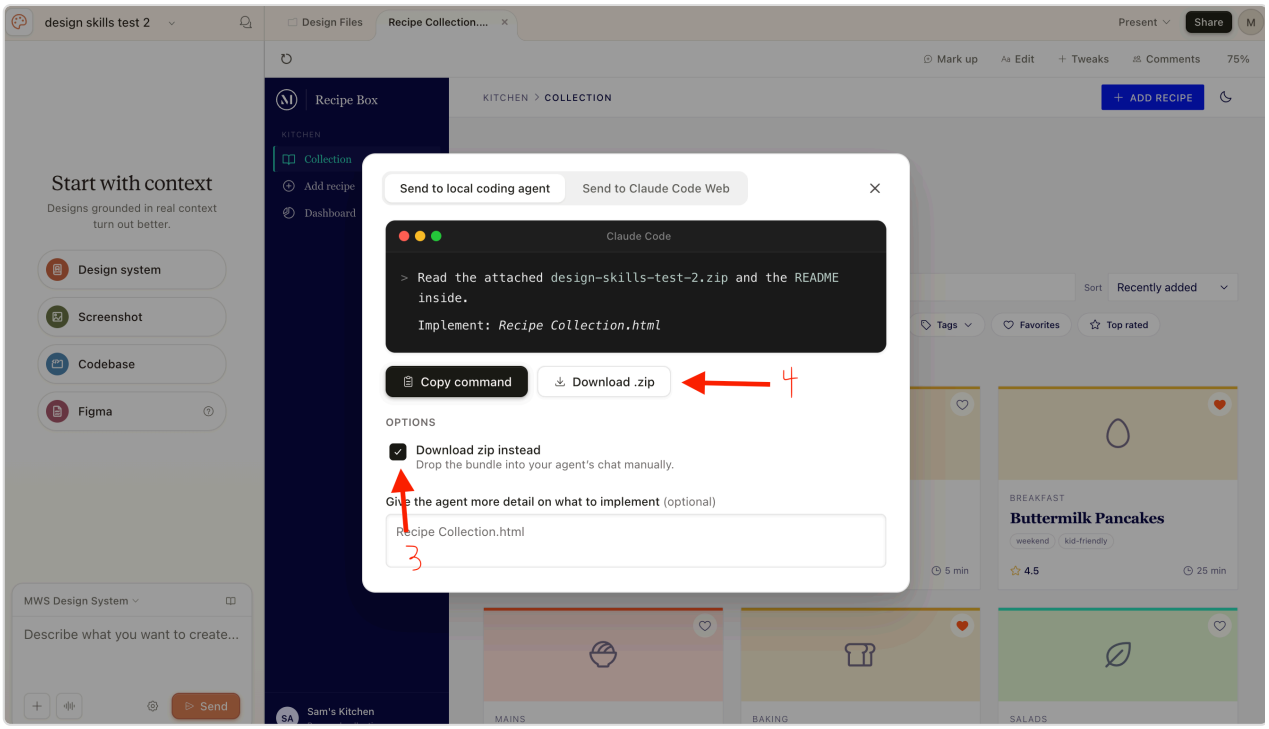
1. In **Claude Design**, export the approved prototype as a project archive (a `.zip` of the full package — not the HTML-only export or a single-screen export). Three ways to do this — **Option A is the preferred path**.

   > **! IMPORTANT — DO NOT SEND STRAIGHT TO CHAT**
   >
   > **Do NOT send the project straight to the Claude Code chat.** The skill needs the archive saved to your `artifacts/docs/design/` folder, not piped into a chat conversation. This applies to all three options below.

   - ⭐ **Option A (preferred) — Share with Claude Code:** Click the **Share button** in the top-right corner (1), then under **Export**, click **"Send"** next to **Claude Code** (2). In the modal that opens, check **"Download zip instead"** (3) and click **"Download .zip"** (4).

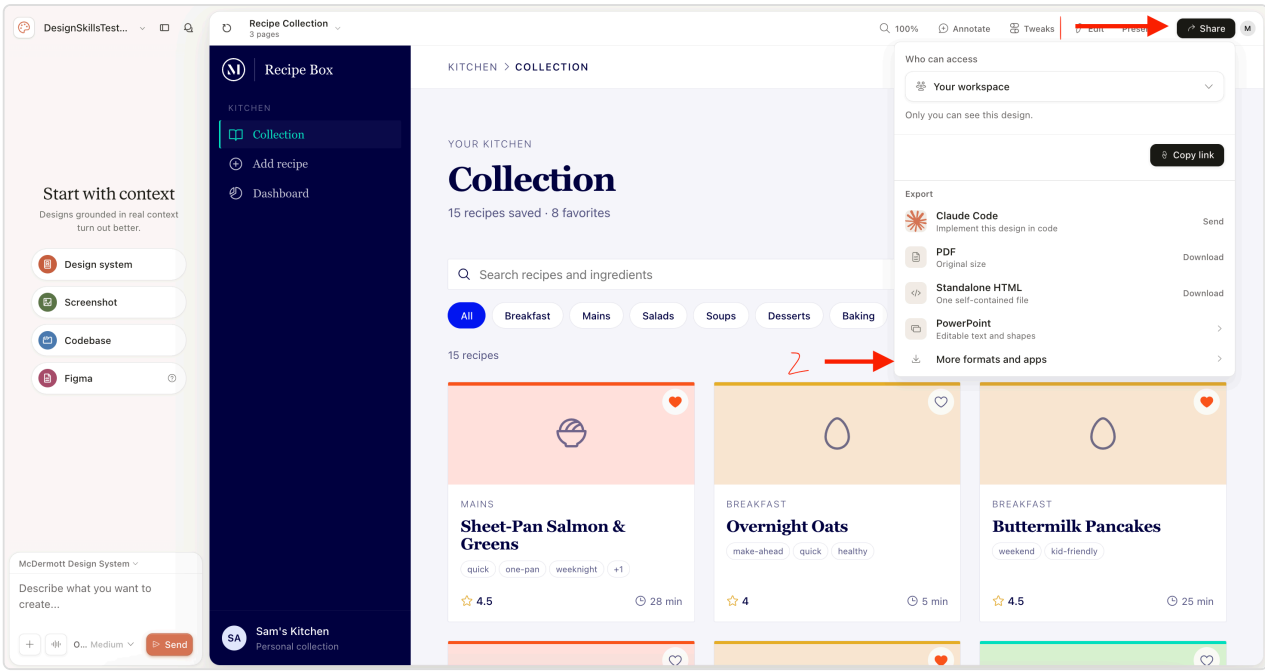


Steps 1-2: Click the Share button, then click Send next to Claude Code under Export.

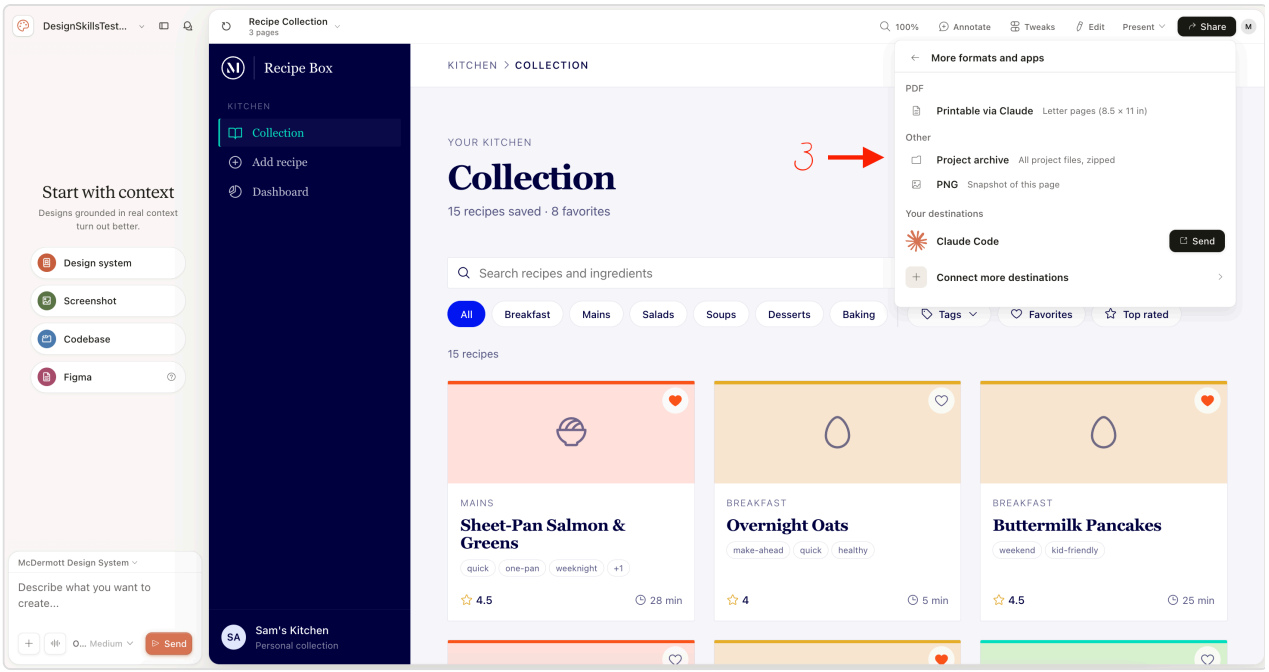


Steps 3-4: Check "Download zip instead," then click "Download .zip."

- **Option B — More formats and apps:** Click the **Share button** in the top-right corner (1), then click **"More formats and apps"** (2). In the panel that opens, click **"Project archive"** under **Other** to download the zipped project files (3).

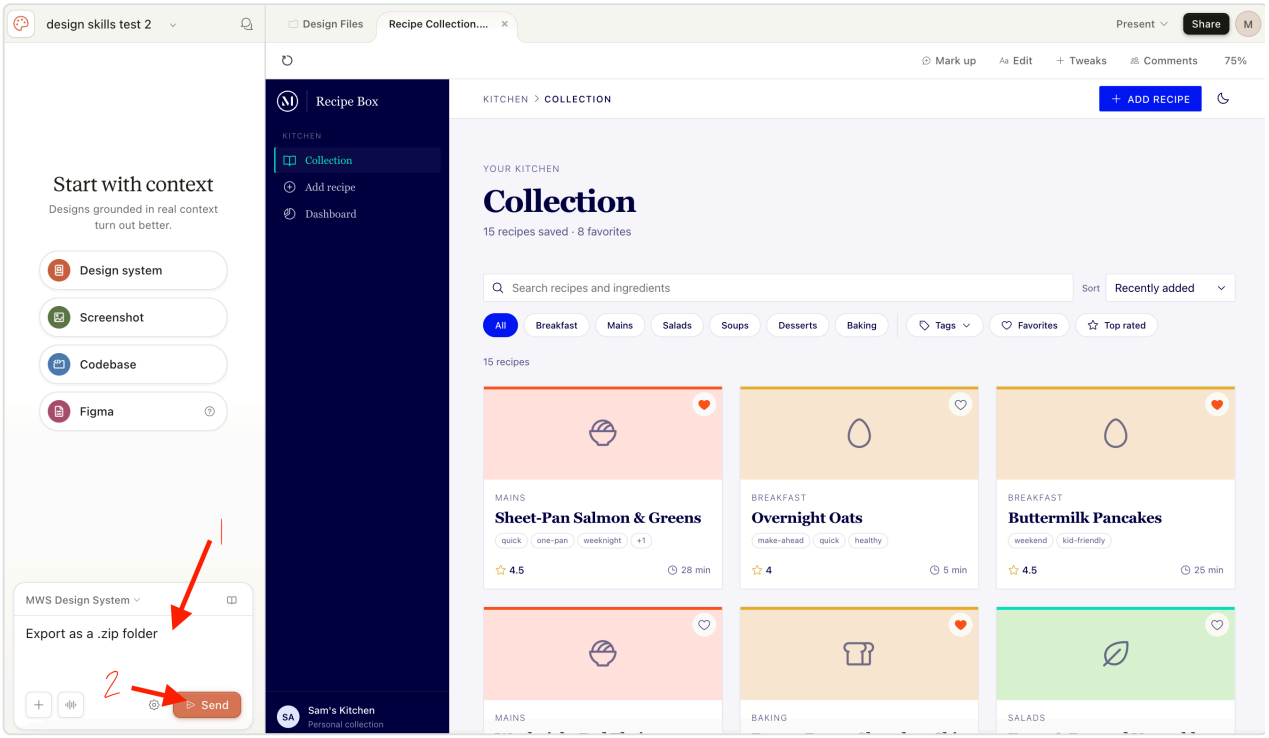


Steps 1-2: Click the Share button, then click "More formats and apps."

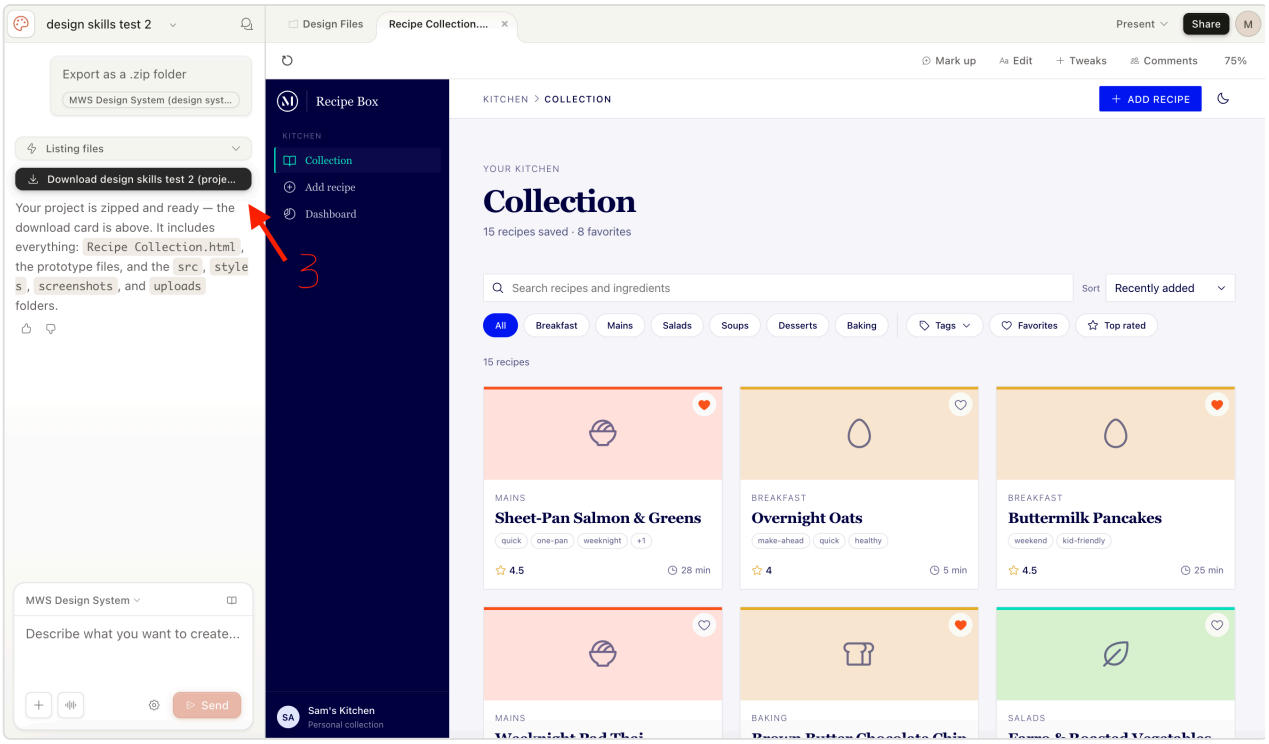


Step 3: Click "Project archive" under Other to download all project files, zipped.

- **Option C — Ask in chat:** In the **chat panel** on the left, type "*I would like to export this project as a .zip folder*", click **Send**, then download the zip from Claude Design's response.



Steps 1-2: Type your request in the chat panel, then click Send.



Step 3: Download the zip from Claude Design's response.

2. On your computer, move or copy the downloaded project archive into `artifacts/docs/design/` (inside your app folder — e.g., `C:\Users\[user_name]\claude_apps\[app_name]\artifacts\docs\design\`). It's the same folder where `full-design-blueprint.md` already lives.

> **! UPLOAD INTO THE WORKTREE BRANCH, NOT THE MAIN APP FOLDER**
>
> Because you're running with **worktree** checked (Step 2), the next step (`/design-code-handoff`) reads from the worktree's copy of `artifacts/docs/design/` — not the one in your main app folder. Make sure the prototype archive is placed inside the **worktree branch's** `artifacts/docs/design/` folder. If it's only in the main folder, the skill won't see it and will report that the archive is missing.
>
> **Not sure which folder that is?** Ask Claude in the chat: "*please give me the destination folder*". Claude will reply with the full path to the worktree's `artifacts/docs/design/` folder — click into it to open the right location, then drop your prototype archive there.

> **Tip:** keep the project archive's folder structure intact (don't unzip or rearrange it). The next step's skill will rename the file to `project/` automatically so every project uses the same canonical path. Claude Design typically packages a few different versions of each screen inside the archive (and may also produce loose HTML files from previous Step 6 sharing) — the skill identifies which one is the right version for the build using the file's structure, so no cleanup is needed on your end.

✅ Step 8 — Reconcile the plan with the prototype

Claude Code · design-code-handoff

⏱️ **Time:** 5-15 minutes

> **YOUR PART —** *Confirm the prototype archive is in place.*

1. Run `/design-code-handoff` from your active directory. It asks whether you've dropped the prototype archive into `artifacts/docs/design/` (Step 7) — reply **"ready"**.
2. The skill reconciles the plan to match your prototype and updates the files for you — **automatically, with no sign-off** and no prep on your part. **What gets built is your prototype, plus the screens you saved for /build** — so there's nothing to review or edit here. Move on to Step 9 when it's done.

> **! IMPORTANT — DO NOT EDIT AFTER HANDOFF**
>
> **Do NOT edit the requirements or blueprint after the handoff.** This is the point where both documents are final. Step 8 has **already reconciled them to match your prototype**, and `/plan` → `/build` read them **exactly as the handoff left them. Please don't hand-edit** `solution-requirements.md` **or** `full-design-blueprint.md` **between the handoff and** `/plan` — changes you make here aren't part of the reconciled plan and can quietly desync the build from what you actually approved. Do all your shaping in **Steps 3–8**; once the handoff has run, treat both documents as locked and move straight to `/plan`.

🚀 Step 9 — Plan the build

Claude Code · Opus 4.7

⏱️ **Time:** 15 minutes

> **YOUR PART —** *Run `/plan` and answer scoping questions as they come up.*

In **Claude Code**, run `/plan` to start the build pipeline. It reads everything in place — your reconciled blueprint, requirements doc, and prototype export folder — and produces the build plan that drives the rest of the implementation.

What to watch for:

- Claude may pause with clarifying questions about scope, tier, or edge cases — answer them promptly. The plan's quality depends on it.
- When it finishes, skim the plan before running `/build`. Catching scope issues here is much cheaper than fixing them mid-build.

🛠️ Step 10 — Build the product

Claude Code · Sonnet 5

⏱️ **Time:** 45-60 minutes (depends on size of the product)

> **YOUR PART —** *Switch to Sonnet 5, then run `/build`.*

> **Switch to Sonnet 5 for this step.** In Claude Code's model picker, change from Opus 4.7 to **Sonnet 5** before running `/build`. Sonnet 5 is faster and better-suited for the implementation work in `/build` and `/ship`.

In **Claude Code**, run **`/build`** to implement the build plan from Step 9. It writes the code for your product, screen by screen — building the prototyped screens to match the prototype, and the remaining "save for /build" screens from the blueprint, styled to match.

What to watch for:

- Claude works screen by screen — watch each one as it lands and compare it to your prototype. Flagging a mismatch early is much cheaper than a rebuild later.
- If a screen goes off-course, interrupt and correct it before Claude moves on. Wrong patterns tend to propagate to later screens.

🚢 Step 11 — Ship the product

Claude Code · Sonnet 5

⏱️ **Time:** 15-30 minutes

> **YOUR PART —** *Stay on Sonnet 5, then run `/ship`.*

> **Stay on Sonnet 5 for this step.** If you're continuing from Step 10 you're already set. Otherwise, switch to **Sonnet 5** in Claude Code's model picker before running `/ship`.

In **Claude Code**, run **`/ship`** to finalize and deploy your product.

What to watch for:

- Watch for the deploy URL or completion confirmation in Claude's final message — that's your signal `/ship` finished successfully.
- If `/ship` surfaces test or lint failures, fix them rather than skipping — they'll block the deploy.

> **Switch back to Opus 4.7 when `/ship` finishes.** Sonnet 5 is only for `/build` and `/ship`. Return to **Opus 4.7** in Claude Code's model picker before starting your next project or moving on to Step 12.

🧪 Step 12 — Test the app locally

Claude Code · Opus 4.7

⏱️ **Time:** 10-15 minutes

> **YOUR PART —** *Copy the prompt for your operating system and paste it into Claude Code.*

> **Note:** This is a temporary solution for the Build-a-thon. Claude Code will start the frontend and API services, create a database, and launch the web app so you can view it locally.

Windows — copy this prompt into Claude Code:

```
Launch the app locally for testing.

My environment:
- .NET SDK 10, MS SQL Server 2025 LocalDB
- Frontend: React (TypeScript/Vite), Middle tier: .NET Web API, Database: LocalDB

1. Confirm or set up the LocalDB connection string in appsettings.Development.json
2. Apply any pending database migrations
3. Start the .NET API and React frontend (restore packages if needed)
4. Add a dev-only Entra auth bypass:
   - Skip token validation in the API when ASPNETCORE_ENVIRONMENT=Development
   - Inject a mock user so all API endpoints work without a real token
   - Skip MSAL sign-in in the React frontend and go straight to the app
5. Tell me the localhost URLs for both once running

Rules:
- Auth bypass must never activate outside Development
- Do not commit or push any of these local testing changes to dev
- Add all bypass/test files to .gitignore
```

Mac — copy this prompt into Claude Code:

```
Launch the app locally for testing.

My environment:
- .NET SDK 10, SQL Server running in a Docker container (Mac)
- Frontend: React (TypeScript/Vite), Middle tier: .NET Web API, Database: SQL Server
container

1. Check if the SQL Server Docker container is running, start it if not
2. Confirm or set up the connection string in appsettings.Development.json pointing
to the container
3. Apply any pending database migrations
4. Start the .NET API and React frontend (restore packages if needed)
5. Add a dev-only Entra auth bypass:
   - Skip token validation in the API when ASPNETCORE_ENVIRONMENT=Development
   - Inject a mock user so all API endpoints work without a real token
   - Skip MSAL sign-in in the React frontend and go straight to the app
6. Tell me the localhost URLs for both once running

Rules:
- Auth bypass must never activate outside Development
- Do not commit or push any of these local testing changes to dev
- Add all bypass/test files to .gitignore
```

Once Claude finishes, it will give you the localhost URLs for the frontend and API. Open the frontend URL in your browser to view the app.

If something goes wrong

- **The prototype is cluttered or off-brand:** add more of the McDermott design system to Claude Design and rebuild.
- **The prototype diverged from the plan:** that's fine. design-code-handoff handles it — it reconciles the blueprint to match what you actually built, automatically.
- **You have questions during the build:** answers should be in `full-design-blueprint.md`. If they're not, the gap is in the plan — go back and add detail.
- **design-code-handoff says it can't read the prototype:** the project archive's HTMLs may all be expired files or placeholders. To recover:
  1. Open `artifacts/docs/design/`.
  2. Delete the project archive (`.zip` and any `project/` folder; keep the blueprint and brief).
  3. In Claude Design, export the most recent iteration as a standalone HTML (Share menu → Export → Standalone HTML, or ask in the chat panel).
  4. Drop the standalone HTML into `artifacts/docs/design/`.
  5. Run `/design-code-handoff` again.

Quick reference

Step	What you do	Model	What you get	⏱ Time
🧰 1. Set up a new application	Install the project template + create app folder in PowerShell / Terminal	—	App folder ready at `C:\Users\[user_name]\claude_apps\[app_name]\`	5-10 min
💻 2. Open your project in Claude Code	Launch Claude Desktop; point Claude Code at your app folder	Opus 4.7	Working folder set	< 5 min
📝 3. Gather requirements	Run **`/requirements-gathering`** in Claude Code	Opus 4.7	Your requirements, written up	10-30 min (prep may take longer)
📋 4. Create a blueprint	Run **`/design-foundation`**; review the sitemap and sign off on the selection	Opus 4.7	`full-design-blueprint.md` + `HANDOFF-design-brief.md` + `sitemap.html`	5-10 min
⚙️ Setup. Design system *(if needed)*	Set up the McDermott design system in Claude Design	—	Design system ready to use	5-20 min
🎨 5. Build the prototype	Drive Claude Design to build screens one at a time	—	Approved prototype	5-30 min per screen
💬 6. Share for review *(optional)*	Export the prototype and collect feedback	—	Refined prototype	Varies
📦 7. Export the prototype folder	Save the project archive into `artifacts/docs/design/`	—	Prototype folder ready for reconciliation	5 min
✅ 8. Reconcile with prototype	Run **`/design-code-handoff`**; confirm the archive is in place	Opus 4.7	Reconciled blueprint (applied automatically)	5-15 min

Step	What you do	Model	What you get	⏱ Time
🚀 9. Plan the build	Run `/plan` (or hand off to a developer)	Opus 4.7	Build plan	15 min
🛠️ 10. Build the product	Run `/build` in Claude Code	**Sonnet 5**	Implemented product	45-60 min (depends on size)
🚢 11. Ship the product	Run `/ship` in Claude Code	**Sonnet 5**	Deployed product	15-30 min
🧪 12. Test the app locally *(Build-a-thon temporary)*	Paste the OS-specific prompt into Claude Code	Opus 4.7	App running locally on your machine	10-15 min

Three Claude Code skills, three build commands, one prototype tool. You're shaping decisions at every step — Claude handles the structured work in between.